

Oceans indentured laborers had to cross from India to the Caribbean). Foremost among these is Tejaswini Niranjana, whose perspective on the Caribbean, especially the Indo-Caribbean, is refreshingly nuanced. Her point of view is, on the one hand, from the "Third World" (or global South): "What happens when a Third World scholar travels to another Third World space? What does it mean to have knowledge not inflected by those endless, invariable comparisons with the West?" (Srinivasan). It is especially in the latter question that I see the potential to answer Walter Rodney's call to see "with our own [non-white] eyes." All the afore-mentioned discourses of identity presuppose or build on received Western (often colonial) knowledge regarding, for example, self-image. Here we have the possibility to each look directly at the other (but not as Other). If we no longer have the cultural connectivity that once bound us, across the *kala pani*, then we must "see" each other and ourselves anew, and this time, without the divisive veil created by the legacy of European hegemony (the former Colonizer in new globalized garb).

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MOTHERS-HYPHENATED IMAGINATIONS: THE FEASTS OF SOPAREE KE MAI AND LA DIVINA PASTORA IN TRINIDAD

Teruyuki Tsuji

Each year, on Holy Thursday and Good Friday, a number of Hindu devotees make a pilgrimage to an oldest Catholic Church in the small town of Siparia in southern Trinidad. They pray passionately at the feet of the statue of the Virgin, referred to as *La Divina Pastora*, believing in her healing power. Remarkably, Catholics make their devotion to exactly the same statue on the second Sunday after Easter. The chapel is packed with thousands of Catholics from all over the island, who passionately pray for whatever brings them to this village. This article presents the Hindu pilgrimage to the statue of Catholic Virgin as an ethnographic case study from which we can critically reflect on concepts of cultural mixing, such as creolization and hybridization.

Introduction

It is two o'clock in the morning. There is no sign that the number of pilgrims is diminishing. Indeed, the procession line is becoming longer. It now meanders through the Parish Hall¹ and reaches so far into the dark outside that I cannot see its end. When the pilgrims finally arrive at the feet of the statue, they linger. In spite of the endless line behind them and the hours that everybody has been waiting, nobody urges anyone to hurry. Those in line wait patiently for their turn. Each year on Holy Thursday and Good Friday before Easter, scores of pilgrims travel to a small town in southern Trinidad, called Siparia, from all over the island, and pray fervently at the feet of *La Divina Pastora*, the dark-skinned virgin and the tutelary deity of the Catholic Church.

However, the pilgrims are not Catholics; almost all of them are Hindus. The unfolding scenes of pilgrimage are visibly Hindu. The pilgrims shower the statue of the Virgin with flowers, grains of rice, and oil as they usually do on *murtis*, the effigies of Hindu gods/goddesses, during *puja* or other Hindu rites at home or in a *Mandir*. Many pilgrims, particularly female devotees, were formally dressed with traditional attire such as *kurta*,² and wore a *tika* mark on their foreheads.³ Many had their newborn babies' first haircut performed in front of the statue in the belief that doing so brings fertility. In the meantime, barbers had set up hundreds of stalls on both sides of the streets that surrounded the church to meet the pilgrims' request to complete their haircuts. After midnight of Holy Thursday, a group of Hindu men marched in the Parish Hall beating various forms of *tassa*, a percussion

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instrument popular in the Indo-Caribbean community. The next morning, a humbly dressed Hindu priest (*pundit*) arrived. He remained in his seat offered by a member of the Church until the last group of devotees offered their prayer and left the Parish Hall in the afternoon of Good Friday. Most families stopped by the *pundit* on the way out, asking for a prayer. They touched or kissed the *pundit's* toe, also having touched and kissed the toe of the statue of Catholic Mother in conformity with Hindu custom. Apparently, the Catholic statue and the Hindu *pundit* constituted equally significant parts of the devotional pilgrimage.

This article presents this annual Hindu pilgrimage to the statue of the Virgin, popularly known as "Coolie Fête" in Trinidad, as an ethnographic case study from which we can reflect critically on the relevance of conventional conceptions of cultural mixing. Supplementing original ethnographic observation with historical analysis, I will propose some conceptual problems innate to creolization and the current abstraction of culture as hybrid.

The poststructuralists' refusal of functionalist approaches to culture has directed much scholarly attention to the previously ignored "culture of resistance." In this construction, wherever and whenever it occurs, a dialogue between putatively distinct cultural practices and worldviews develops into a permanent "politics of culture," in which mutual superimposition takes place, without, however, producing an alternative "shared culture" (Werbner, 1997; Osugi, 1999). Indeed, although "tolerance" and "harmony" apparently characterize the current Coolie Fête, its history is marked by repeated conflict. The Roman Catholics in Siparia strove to prevent the intrusion of "pagans," the bearers of foreign and "spurious" cultures; the Hindu celebrants of the statue resisted the Catholics' stigmatization and continuously transgressed colonial bounds of reificatory cultures. However, I believe that the Coolie Fête demonstrates that the enduring dialogical divisions and contrast of reified cultural essences do not necessarily result in a clear-cut identification of concerned subjects and render their relations political and contestatory.

The Coolie Fête has inspired ethnographic inquiries. From my perspective, however, most extant studies fail to grasp the broader implications that the Coolie Fête has had for intergroup relations in Trinidad. This is chiefly because they usually explore the Coolie Fête as an independent and subject-dependent development with almost exclusive focus upon the signifying practices of the agents. The Coolie Fête, however, has evolved in continuous close interaction with the Catholic feast of the same statue, called the "Siparia Fête." Ritualistically repeated, Catholics' transfiguration of the statue's self, with their original intention of preventing "spurious" cultural influence, eventually related dialectically with the ritual practices of Hindu devotees, forming a signifying system. Only by being performed side-by-side can the devotions for the Hindu Mother and the Catholic Mother allow the practitioners both to "mix" with others across socially accepted ethnic bounds and

to repeatedly confirm the putative "purity" of their own ritual practices and relative consciences—the Coolie Fête and the Siparia Fête are simultaneously cultures and a culture.

A Mother: A Bone of Contention

Fr. Cornelius O'Hanlon, a curate of the Catholic Church in Siparia, explored the origins of *La Divina Pastora* in Siparia in the baptism registers written circa 1871: "[I]t is impossible to give the correct date when the statue came here" (*Catholic News*, 1962: 4). It is widely agreed that the statue of *La Divina Pastora* was originally brought to Trinidad via Venezuela after it was first brought to the New World as the "shepherd" of the missionary work of Aragonese Capuchin monks. There is, however, no agreement as to how and when it reached the island. One story says that the statue was brought to Trinidad in 1730 by a group of Capuchin monks fleeing an Amerindian revolt in Venezuela (Comins, 1893; see also Goldwasser, 1996: 214), whereas another story claims that one of the priests took the statue with him when he visited Trinidad to spread the Gospel in 1784 (Osugi, 1999: 181).

Nor is there confirmation of when Hindustanis first found power in this deity and began their pilgrimages. However, according to Fr. O'Hanlon's comments in the baptismal records, large-scale Hindu pilgrimages were already occurring in the late 1860s (McNeal, 2002: 76). In his diary, Fr. Abbé Massé,⁴ Fr. O'Hanlon successor, left the earliest detailed account of the Hindu pilgrimage to the statue in 1884⁵:

All along the way yesterday, the eve of the feast, I met pilgrims of all colours going towards the sanctuary. They were counted in thousands. . . . The road is very difficult and extremely uneven. Among the vehicles which try to come to Siparia, several broke down on the road. One cab tumbled into a ditch; many horses took fright and refused to go further. All eventually though arrived at Siparia. . . Siparia is a very small village lost in the forest, with about 130 inhabitants who live in miserable huts with roofs of timite palm. There is no hotel, just two or three *ajoupas*⁶ where provisions and drinks are sold. The pilgrims sleep under the night sky. The presbytery is barely more comfortable. A hammock, or a mattress on the floor, or a carpet, are the choices I have to offer the visiting priests. All day long the pilgrims come to prostrate at the feet of La Divine—French, English, Spanish (whites and coloureds), Portuguese, Chinese, Indians mainly pagans (cited in De Verteuil, 2000: 225–226).

Understandably, Fr. Masse focused on the Hindus' "paganism," represented by their sacrificial rite in the presence of the Catholic Mother:

A band of coolies arrive. They sing all night long. At dawn they go to bathe and then come to the chapel. They have brought two cocks which they wish to offer to the Virgin. To make this offering they got to the foot of the altar with the cock which they put beside them. After prostrating themselves several times and saying their prayers in a loud voice with arms extended, they go to the back of the church, untie the cock and set it free in the church. The old sacristan then captures the cock, which the cure will soon eat.

Without precautions being taken they would have set the church on fire with the numerous candles they were lighting. The lamps, though there were huge numbers of them, were not sufficient: the oil spilled all over the floorboards. They were disputing among themselves, jostling to obtain the oil, which was burning in front of the Virgin. The coolies have a noisy devotion. They pray at the top of their voices, but then they are distracted. When they prostrate themselves with their forehead on the floor, it seems sometimes that they will split their skull, so hard do they hit their head against the planks (cited in De Verteuil, 2000: 226).

By the 1870s, reports from various sources about the "paganism" of the Hindu faith and ritual practices had excited public repugnance. A leaflet published in the early 1880s by a Catholic priest excoriates a fire-walking ceremony, in which the half-naked "coolies [were] running through fire [toward] idols and devils." With a splash headline, "Betting + Notice + Betting," the flyer underscores the ceremony's depravity by stressing that "five dollars will be given to any Coolies stopping for five minutes in a burning fire. If he cannot, he will lose same sum" (*Newsday*, 2000: 20). Under pressure from the Christian community, the colonial administration prohibited the fire-walking and hook-swinging ceremonies that were occasionally conducted on the island (Vertovec, 2000: 68). Concurrently, the attitude of Catholic authorities toward the Hindu pilgrimage to *La Divina Pastora* reversed the initial tolerance or, at least, indifference. In 1917, the then parish priest, who could no longer condone "pagans" having their way in a Catholic church, put up a notice banning the "Coolie Fête at Siparia" and declared that he would not hesitate to resort to force if the warning was not followed (Goldwasser, 1996: 229; Osugi, 1999: 195; De Verteuil, 2000: 226). In the 1920s, another priest locked out Hindu devotees with a notice in five languages (Boodoo, 2000: 69).

It should be noted that the conflict had first occurred between the preexisting sociocultural groups and East Indian indentured laborers within a few decades after the first group of workers arrived from India in 1845. The real and putative antipathy between groups of workers—based on the assumption of incommensurability of cultural variances—justified planters' and colonial administrators' practice of strict labor regimentation for the sake of social stability (Khan, 2004); as a result, an ethnic division of labor took form, which divided workers into self-contained "sections," between which there was little or no communication. The premises of this ethnic division, which permitted the dominance of the European or European Creole elites, underlie the scholarly analyses that examine colonial society from the perspectives of cultural pluralism (Furnival, 1948; Smith, 1965) and the plantation society model (Beckford, 1972).

As Trouillot (2002: 201) argues, however, no matter how strong the planters' hopes for this ideal type of plantation society was, the actual control of labor was always within limits imposed by circumstances, including demography, economic efficiency of production, and the employer's political power. Until the late 19th century, non-Christian religious practices were tolerated unless they interfered

with the scheduled operation of estates. Employers allegedly supported the religious activities of East Indian workers at times by providing materials necessary for worship (Tikasingsh, 1980: 134 in Vertovec, 1992: 111). A shared view of indentured laborers as merely sojourners, who would repatriate on the expiration of the contract, might have caused either toleration or at least indifference toward non-Christian ritual practices in plantation districts. In addition, to follow Trouillot (2002), the employers' approval of the laborers' religious activities might have reflected the state of the island's sugar production in the second half of the 19th century, which, because of their dependence on indentured workers, imposed significant limits on the planters' power over laborers' cultural expression.

Although the latitude in the institution of indentured servitude allowed the laborers' cultural expression and a certain degree of mobility, it would not have brought about an interaction between distinct symbolic interests and spiritual needs by itself. The various meanings connoted by the symbol of the Mother and the implicit politics of heterosexuality, which were innate to distinct religious traditions, both served common interests and caused conflict between them. The conflict over the Mother in Siparia indeed intensified the contrasts and oppositions between religious and ethnic collectivities. At the same time, however, distinct cultural practices, symbolic elements, and relative worldviews, which would have otherwise remained isolated, were brought into the same temporal and spatial limits (Simmel, 1955: 26).

Mothers: "Purity" as sine qua non for "Mixing"

Throughout the 19th century, Hindus made devotions along with Catholic pilgrims in the main chapel on the same day. However, in the 1910s, as Christian elites assailed the public exhibition of "paganism," Holy Thursday and Good Friday were appointed for the Hindu pilgrimage, which came to be known as the "Coolie Fête" (Osugi, 1999: 195). This temporal separation was followed by a change in spatial arrangements. For the "Coolie Fête," the statue was moved from the altar in the chapel where it was ordinarily enshrined. It was first transferred to the presbytery next door, and then in the 1960s, at the request of Fr. Powers, the parish priest at that time, the statue was moved to the yard of the adjoining Boys' Catholic School during the days of the Hindu feast (Goldwasser, 1996: 229). The statue reached its present location in the Parish Hall around the year 2000 when Church personnel decided to move it out of the schoolyard because of the "insecure[ity]" caused by beggars crowding the premises.⁷

The day prior to the Hindu pilgrimage, the members of the Catholic Church in Siparia, barely resting, fulfill their assigned responsibilities. By the time of my fieldwork it had become a cliché among them that this apparently unique interreligious cooperation has been possible because of Catholic "tolerance." However, my observation was that the wholehearted preparation by church

personnel for the Coolie Fête involved the careful inscription of several dividing lines between “our Mother” and “their Mother” by separating the statue from the church’s ordinary arrangements.

Historically, Hindu pilgrims have called the statue of *La Divina Pastora* “*Soparee Ke Mai*,”⁸ which is now widely interpreted as the “Mother of Siparia.” In the early 1870s, Fr. O’Hanlon noted, “For the East Indians the Black Virgin is really ‘Suparee,’ the name of a seed which is used in their religious ceremonies, and also the name of a powerful saint in India. . . . [T]hey refer to her as ‘Suparee-Ke-Mai,’ rather than to ‘La Divin’” (Marie-Thâérèse, 1976: 56). Later in his diary in 1883, Fr. Massé also described a “young pagan coolie” who prayed fervently for a cure of a sore on his leg at the feet of the statue while calling her “Siparie-Maie” (Massé, 1988 vol. II: 260).

The difference between *La Divina Pastora* and *Soparee Ke Mai* is much more than nominal. Catholics do not see the *Soparee Ke Mai* as identical with *La Divina Pastora*. Almost all the laypersons of Siparia Church whom I interviewed underscored that the statue “becomes their mother on the days of Coolie Fête.” To my question why the crowd of Hindustanis does not bother her, a middle-aged congregant of the Church answered: “NO. No problem at all. . . . ‘Cause, you know, they call her *Soparee Mai*. They come meet their mother. *Suparee* or *Soparee* . . . not sure if I pronounce correctly, anyway, it is their mother.” An aged female member had similar views:

Hindu people know she belong to Catholic. They said, they know Jesus had a mother. They consider her their mother, too. They meet her and ask her whatever they need. In return, whatever she asks, they bring whatever she ask to, oil, candle, clothes. . . . She go out see them . . . She becomes their mother on the day . . . that day is Holy Thursday. They really believe that she is *Siparia Mai*. [So, you do not really matter if they come see her?] Oh, no. Oh, no. That believe . . . that she is there for them these days. Don’t criticize it. Shouldn’t criticize it.

Besides the spatial arrangement, in the Catholic’s transfiguration of the statue—from Catholic Mother, *La Divina Pastora*, to Hindu Mother, *Soparee Ke Mai*—the dress performs a critical symbolic role. After the statue is taken down from the top of the altar, female parishioners change the statue’s dress to one tailored for this particular occasion. Then, before the male members move onto the handmade wooden pedestal set in the Parish Hall, they adorn the dress with jewellery and ornaments donated by Hindu devotees, and applied makeup and cosmetics to the statue.

In his dairy of the 1880s, Fr. Massé noted the statue’s dress:

Like all the Spanish Virgins that of Siparia is dressed. O’Hanlon does not worry about his own clothes, worried himself less again with that of the Blessed Virgin. She has worn the same dress for several years. It is not because they were lacking. Her wardrobe is well furnished I can assure you. No year passes without her being offered several blouses, shirts

and dresses. Among the last named there were some very pretty ones. I had the dirty dress buried and replaced it by another new one (cited in De Verteuil, 2000: 254).

Fr. O’Hanlon’s strong desire to make the statue resemble the Holy Virgin in Rome with a “dress of very good taste” (De Verteuil, 2000: 254) seems not to have crystallized. Until the 1960s, the statue’s dress was changed only when the devotees donated materials for new clothes (Goldwasser, 1996). In other words, the dressing of the statue had not been done ritually. The turning point came in the 1960s when an “old Indian lady” manifested herself in the dream of Ms. R., one of the “older heads” of the Church, who had been in charge of tailoring, cleaning, and changing the statue’s dresses for more than 40 years. She then started putting a new dress on the statue every Easter Sunday morning following the feast days of *Soparee Ke Mai*. Ms. R. explains the circumstances in which she decided to tailor the “second dress”:

The first year . . . no following year, she asked me to change her clothes. I came to the church here. In dream, you know? And she was in the yard standing like an old Indian lady. And she called me, “Hey gal! Come.” I go. “They invited me a party. You think I could go with this dress . . . clean enough?” I saw nothing wrong with the dress. I said, “Yeah! You could go like that!” I saw her. The dress was clean. She said, “Oh, right.” She walked for a while and continued to go heading to church. But turned around and called me back. I said, “What’s wrong?” She said, “Gal! I don’t feel well about my dress, you know?” “What’s wrong? Nothing wrong with it.” “You think I could go see my son like this?” Now when I watched the skirt underneath, the oil was falling. Because the Indians really pour the oil on her dress. So the oil was falling. When she showed me it, I said, “All right. Right. Right. I will fix that for you. I fix that for you.” I came to Father. . . . Father Powers at that time and told him what happened. “What you think? What’s your opinion? You are priest, so you should guide me or tell me what I should do.” Father Power asked me back, “Can you?” I said, “Yes! I could make the second dress.” I went home. Oh, before that, I stopped by the nun’s home. I told her that she asked me for my favor and I could do it for her. She told me, “You know you could do it. So do it.” So I decide going to do it. I said, “Sister, if somebody ask you to come meet at a party, you go with such a home dress? You will get a nice dress, clean dress to go, right? She is the mother come and ask me for my favor. I said, “I am going to do it.” Easter Sunday morning . . . beautiful sunrise! With a dirty dress, she wouldn’t be happy about it. If she ask me to do it, I am going to do it. Make the second dress.

Over the years, the statue’s dress came to be changed more frequently. Ms. R. now does it seven times a year. The feast for *Soparee Ke Mai* was the first occasion when the statue started wearing the separate “second dress.” Before then she had the same dress throughout the year, regardless of who was paying her homage. It may not be a coincidence that the ritual changes of dress began when the statue also started moving out of the chapel for the duration of the Hindu feast. The function of the statue’s dress as a symbolic marker of its distinct identities was reinforced when Ms. R. undertook the ritualistic change also before the Hindu feast on Holy Thursday morning.

When the Hindu pilgrimage was over, the statue was restored as *La Divina Pastora* through the same activities in reverse order. In order “not to disturb the [Saturday morning] Mass” the statue was left as it was in the Parish Hall from the evening of Good Friday. On Saturday afternoon, church members returned the statue to the chapel. Before restoring it to the top of altar, Ms. R. removed the statue’s dress, from which “olive oil was falling” and dressed the statue with a freshly tailored dress for the Catholic Easter celebration. The dress for the Hindu feast is either thrown away or “give[n] to anyone who wants it as a souvenir.” When Ms. R. completed changing the statue’s clothes, she stated with a sense of peacefulness of the world having returned to it proper order, “Now she happy to go see her son.”

Alfred Mendes, a noted Trinidadian man of letters, reconstructed his observation of the Hindu pilgrimage to the statue of *La Divina Pastora* on a Good Friday in a short story published in the early 1930s:

[W]e entered the church. There was, I felt, some mistake when we entered. What I saw I could not believe. I still do not believe in what I saw at that moment and all the succeeding moments. If you entered a lunatic asylum and heard no insane scream, no senseless speech, no battering of head against hard partition, you would stop and wonder if you really were in a lunatic asylum. If you entered a Christian church and could hear only the hullabaloo of Hindustani chatter, the pattering feet of children and the shrieks of babies, you would wonder if you were in a Christian church. . . . And as for the evidence of my eyes,—it was the most incongruous, most amazing sight I had ever seen. Almost every pew in the church was filled with East Indians. The aisles were congested with little groups gesticulating and hotly engaged in choruses of conversation—on what topics I do not know. Shrewd guesses might suggest the blackeye pea crop, the village feud, or perhaps how Mulemeah was raped by Sookdeo (Mendes, 1932: 8).

Observing Hindu devotees who ardently thronged around the statue of the Virgin, this imaginative Christian fantasized that he would “look down upon the figure of Christ and play with the fancy of its miraculously rising up and using the cross as a weapon for striking the idolaters out of the house of God” (Mendes, 1932: 10).

In spite of the current acceptance of the Hindu devotions, this Christian writer reflects a broad concern among the Catholics in Siparia about the incursion of spurious cultures that were perceived as potentially threatening to the putative purity of their own relationship to their specifically Catholic “Mother.” They shared the general colonial contention, represented by Mendes’s remark, that Hindus were unfit to be “true Christians” (Munasinghe, 2001: 197). Nevertheless, beyond the cognizance and imagination of this Port-of-Spain-based intellect, the Coolie Fête was not an unreflective or arbitrary mixing of putative religious traditions. As described above, the Catholics in Siparia have (re)produced oppositions and contrasts between Mothers—the embodiments of the putatively disparate cultural origins—with the Catholic and Hindu Mothers becoming available on different dates, at different places, and with different dresses. The *Soparee Ke Mai* has thus

never been a “mistaken identity [of *La Divina Pastora*]” (196), but a separate and authentic Mother who represents an “untrue” yet tolerated ritual practice and worldview. The Catholics in Siparia consider this figurative distance from the Hindu Mother to have enabled them to prevent the Hindus’ apparent “mixing” from being detrimental to the putative Catholic “purity” of *La Divina Pastora*, and of the Catholic ritual practice and conscience she personifies.

Nests of Transformist Hegemonies: *Soparee Ke Mai* as an “Alternative Construction”

During the entire two days of Coolie Fête, only one Hindu *pundit* turned up. This aroused my curiosity. Unlike a *puja* or other ceremonial and ritual occasions, which usually are community-based, this annual event seemed a rare opportunity for *pundits* to earn the respect of, and sizable donations from, numerous Hindu pilgrims from all of Trinidad. To my question why he had been alone in this occasion, this *pundit* answered curtly, “They don’t like it.” I pressed him further, “Who are they?” He replied, “Big-men,” by which he meant the predominant Sanatanist religious elites, who tend to regard the devotion to *Soparee Ke Mai* as an aberration, if not the target of overt censure. A Sanatanist *pundit* expressed this attitude when interviewed by a local newspaper: “The *La Divina* worship is not related to Hinduism in any way. The Hindus who go worship the Catholic saint do so out of superstition, not out of an identity with any Hindu goddess. . . . The Hindus who go to worship the *La Divina* in the Siparia R.C. Church are not real devotees of Hinduism” (*Trinidad Express*, April 5, 1985: 3, cited in Vertovec, 1992: 220–221). None of the five Sanatanist *pundits* interviewed for this research openly expressed contempt for Hindu pilgrims to the Catholic Church in Siparia. Yet, they gently but firmly refused to accept *Soparee Ke Mai* as a “true” and “real” representation of Hindu orthodoxy. To cite one of the *pundits*: “[It is] their freedom to pay respect to *Soparee Ke Mai*. This is free country. But we don’t do that. It is more like a superstition . . . folk magic. Do you know African *obeah* t’ing? The same t’ing. No one take good care of women like Hindus. But that is a wrong way. True Hindus don’t believe in mother that way.” For these elite Hindus, the “big men,” *La Divina* does indeed violate Hindu purity and they deny that worshipping her constitutes “true” Hindu practice.

Although colonial authorities had expected East Indian indentured laborers to return to their homeland once their contracts expired, many became permanent residents in the late 19th century. In response, the religious leaders, and those who were economically ascending, began working to establish a cohesive Indo-Trinidadian community based on the construction of “Indian-ness” around “Indian religions”—Hinduism and Islam in the Trinidadian context (Khan, 2004).⁹ Under the homogenizing hegemony of the European elites that constantly devalued non-Christian religious representations, all aspects of Hinduism were forced to

reconstruct themselves. Hindu religious elites then strove to recast Hinduism to serve both as a competing plausibility structure, equal to Catholicism and Anglicanism, for the demonopolized religious system (Berger, 1969: 49) and as a diacritical symbol to mobilize the Hindu population in their struggle for the political redress in this multicultural society (Vertovec, 1992, 2000; Munasinghe, 2001; Khan, 2004).

This refashioned "Indian-ness," however, was not a direct transposition or translation of their culture of origin, but a "unique cultural configuration" (Stoler, 1989). The majority of East Indian immigrants to Trinidad came from the northern part of the Indian subcontinent, particularly Uttar Pradesh and Bihar. Despite this geographical concentration of the indentured workers' origins, the sectarian and doctrinal mosaic of India was replicated in the religious landscape of this West Indian colony (Vertovec, 1992, 2000). In India, the caste and religious systems have traditionally retained self-contained symbolic and territorial enclaves in mutually reinforcing relationships. The variety of religious traditions could not have been assimilated into an integrated orthodoxy without the drastic deterritorialization attendant upon migration to Trinidad. On the one hand, indentured laborers' shared living sphere eventually fused the existing dialectical heterogeneity into an "ethnic" *lingua franca* among East India immigrants (Vertovec, 1992: 93–94). On the other hand, it was impossible to restore the caste system, which was a highly parochial phenomenon. As a result, Hinduism was extensively reengineered in Trinidad (95–100).

The codification of Hinduism and the public exhibition of authorized knowledge through repeated ritual performances were indeed acts of resistance against the Christian "transformist hegemony" (Gramsci, 1971). However, this realignment of Hinduism, compelled by the dominating social discipline, established another "transformist hegemony" within the Hindu community. The integration of heterogeneous Hindu traditions was, like Christian-centered assimilation, an asymmetrical process wherein not all elements were equally valued. Some intellectual and ritualistic traditions were appropriated; others were devalued as inconsistent and denied their contribution to the intended "Indian-ness."

With their experience in an elaborate priesthood, Brahmin religious elites led this process, and eventually "monopolized the sacred knowledge of rituals and Sanskrit texts." In Trinidad and other West Indian destinations of East Indian immigrants, where the caste could not serve as a formula for classification, religious experience and ritual knowledge "replaced purity as the legitimation of [their] status" (Van der Burg and Van der Veer, 1986: 517, cited in Vertovec, 2000: 53).

The Brahmin reengineering centered on the standardization of Hinduism as inheritable ethnic capital. To this end, Sanatanist religious leaders have selectively excluded those ritual practices that are viewed by Christians as representation of Hindu "paganism" (e.g., animal sacrifice). They have also striven to expunge ritual

components, exemplified spiritual possession, that may cause spontaneity, fluidity, and diffused sense of collective identity (Van der Veer, 1996: 144). By repeating the standardized ritual as a collective enterprise organized under their tutelage, Brahmin leaders attempted to clarify the remaining pragmatic and ideological ambivalence and to make rituals occasions in which Hindus articulate a shared ethnic identity.

Apparently, the Hindu devotion to *Soparee Ke Mai* is in stark contrast with the orthodox ritual performance as collective and instructional enterprise. First, the devotion is based on the consensus that the relationship between the Mother and the devotees is personal and direct. The pilgrims submit a range of personal issues to the Mother, including the cure of physiological disorders, solutions of financial difficulties, success in academic endeavors, and arbitration of lovers' quarrels. They share the consensus that whether one is saved or not depends on the devotee and his or her morality. The emphasis on the worshipper's direct connection with the Mother enables creative innovation, leading to spontaneity, fluidity, and the diffused sense of the collective, which are the very features the Sanatanists desperately tried to remove from their ritual performance. In my observations in 2003, the loud beat of the *tassa* drums not only "interrupted" the devotion, but also seemed to have provided a rhythm that put some pilgrims into an ecstatic state.

Second, devotion to *Soparee Ke Mai* is homage to an "illegitimate" deity. There used to be no standardized criterion, called orthodoxy, which stratified gods and goddesses. However, in the codified system, a small pantheon of Sanskrit deities, which personified the Brahmins' symbolic status, subordinated a variety of local gods and goddesses, particularly those who were related to "illegitimate" ritual expressions (Vertovec, 1992: 108–112). Reflecting the fluid and indeterminate nature of lay ideology—as opposed to orthodoxy—some Hindus within and beyond this study identify *Soparee Ke Mai* with various manifestations of goddesses (194). For one, *Soparee Ke Mai* has often been viewed as identical or interchangeable with Mother *Kali*, the "black-Mother-goddess" (Naipaul, 1983: 155), despite the striking contrasts in their appearance except for their similar dark complexion. The celebration of *Soparee Ke Mai*, recorded by Fr. Masse in his diary, bears a resemblance to South-Indian style of *Kali Mai* worship, an ecstatic *shakti* ritual that usually includes animal sacrifice to and possession of divine forces. This is not the place to further explore the relationship between *Soparee Ke Mai* and *Kali Mai*.¹⁰ But what is particularly important, is that the devotional practices around these Mothers are regarded equally as "illegitimate" from Sanatanist orthodox viewpoint. In the early religious mosaic replicated by indentured immigrants, *Kali* was consecrated in a community-based ritual under traditional religious leadership, along with gods and goddesses that would later be incorporated as "legitimate" in the constructed Hindu orthodoxy. In the realigned Hinduism, however, *Kali* came to play subordinate and supportive, yet important, roles as a merciful mother. With

her newly assigned status, she does not fly into a fury causing destruction on the living. This implies that *Kali* is no longer subject to ritual performance for propitiation. To repeat the comment of the above-cited Sanatanist *pundit* upon the worship of *Soparee Ke Mai*: "Hindu take good care of women. But [the devotion to *Soparee Ke Mai*] is a wrong way. True Hindus don't believe in mother that way."

Last, but not least, the pilgrimage to Siparia was considered as an "untrue" Hindu ritual practice because of the assumed extraneous and spurious cultural influence. For the Sanatanist *pundits*, the pilgrims to the statue that sits in the Catholic Church—the very domain under the putative cultural domination of Christians and Afro-Trinidadians—are mindless of the unreflective or arbitrary mixing, irrespective of the "true" religious origin, and therefore obscure the defining bounds of the reified form of "Indian religion." From their orthodox viewpoint of the Sanatanists *pundits*, this means nothing but the dilution of identity as "pure" Indians (Khan, 2004: 228).

Yet, my observations of the characteristics of *Soparee Ke Mai* worship challenge the orthodox view of the devotion as transgressive. In fact, the devotees' actions, which are molded round their belief in their personal and unmediated relationships with the Mother, occasionally bring about unpredictability and fluidity in the ritual process, and render the ritual space an apparently "porous ground of mixing" (Khan, 2004: 228) with "spurious" cultures. However, their belief on the individual level is affirmed only if it is consistent with their commitment to the moral community. Within the same system of devotional practice of *Soparee Ke Mai* that places a priority on a personal connection with divine force, there is also an insistence on discipline, which is often expressed in their belief that disrespect and immorality would either cause a disturbance in their relationship with the Mother, or even deserve a severe punishment.¹¹

According to one of the Sanatanist *pundits* whom I interviewed, god or goddess is a pure spirit omnipresent in the universe and yet its appearance assumes certain forms, reflecting different stages of reincarnation. By making use of *murtis*, the Sanatanist Hindus aspire to cultivate their ties with divine forces through devotional practices (*Bhakti*), whereas the "illegitimate" local demigods or spirits are elusive and amorphous, although their names prevail and their power is deemed effective among Hindu laities. Against Sanatanist's classification as "magic" or "superstition," in the perception of the Hindu pilgrims *Soparee Ke Mai* is a manifestation of the female aspect of divinity in a form of a *murti*—the statue that sits in the Catholic Church—that is ready to establish bonds with the followers through their *Bhakti*. In a sense, the Catholic Church has restored the "unauthorized" Hindu deities in conformity with the principle and conception of the orthodoxy, enabling the pilgrims to (re)establish and retain associations with those deities, not individually and surreptitiously, but collectively, overtly, and regularly.

Moreover, beyond the perception of Hindu religious elites, the lay Hindu pilgrims are attentive to the "foreign" and thus, "spurious" cultural influence as much as they are. More precisely, Hindu devotees continue to make devotions to *Soparee Ke Mai* because they do not deem their devotional practice as transgressing the defining bounds of a reified form of Hinduism. The elite-led realignment of Hinduism has resulted in neither a complete replacement of diverse traditions with a codified system of orthodoxy nor a preservation of indigenous ways of worship—in fact, it has modernized and Westernized Hinduism, and produced numerous "alternative constructions" (Nandy, 1983), which enable one to be true to both the reified Hindu orthodoxy that is a necessary medium for status generation and improvement, and to the other self defined as illegitimate by Trinidadian Hindu orthodoxy. For the Hindu pilgrims, their worship of *Soparee Ke Mai* is equipped with the religious fabrics for legitimacy, including logic and *modus operandi* equal to orthodox ritual performances, while allowing them to retain the rationale of personal and direct access to the goddess that is the vital channel of their salvation. In the devotees' perception, this has enabled them to "mix"—the pilgrimage to the Catholic Church—without alienating themselves from the Hindu "community," as defined by reificatory and biologicistic "pure" culture, designated by Trinidadian (post)colonial cultural classification.

The Brahmin-led homogenization of Hinduism, beginning in the late 19th century, coincided with the diversification of socioeconomic milieu of Indo-Trinidadians. More indentured laborers who had served out their contracts left the estates to become peasants, and started cultivating crops according to the condition and location of the land they occupied. Meanwhile, a sizable number of Indo-Trinidadians abandoned agricultural production altogether and streamed into principal cities and suburbs, seeking domestic work or other types of job (Brereton, 1979). The diversification of socioeconomic circumstances in which Hindustanis found themselves entailed the segmentation and personalization of their symbolic interests and spiritual needs. To the contrary, the means of salvation were homogenized and concentrated into fewer hands of religious elites, and ritual performances became larger in scale, increasingly abstract, and intended as extroverted public statements. The immediate and specific spiritual needs of the lay Hindus were gradually dominated by metaphysical and supra-individual causes that the religious elites prioritized in their struggle to improve the status of the Hindu community as a distinctive ethnic collective. The seemingly paradoxical result is that the decentralization of symbolic interests and means of salvation in the devotion to *Soparee Ke Mai* has facilitated the Catholic Church in Siparia in acting as a sanctuary where lay Hindus can retain or (re)develop a direct access to the Mother that has historically represented the immediate matters of their lives.

Conclusion: Sharing Mothers

In addition to the resistance from increasing numbers of Hindu devotees (Boodoo, 1993, 2000),¹² chronic fiscal crises and limited political authority constrained the leaders of the Catholic Church in their attempts to exclude non-Christian, Hindu devotees. To the contrary, these factors prompted Catholic priests and parishioners to mingle with the Hindus regardless of their evident cultural alterity.

The issue of the Ecclesiastical Ordinance of 1844 was followed by a substantial reduction of public allowance from the colonial fund to the Roman Catholic Church in Trinidad. This had greater repercussions on rural parishes, such as Siparia (Ottley, 1974; Harricharan, 1993). L.A. De Verteuil (1884: 314) described Siparia in the 1880s, the same period when Fr. Massé reported the surprising Hindu pilgrims: "[The Mission of Siparia] had then a resident padre or priest, a corregidor, and a schoolmaster. The present condition of the Mission is far from affording the same pleasant aspect, its population being reduced, cultivations neglected, houses in a dilapidated state. . . . Siparia is now completely neglected." Nevertheless, the construction of a new chapel and presbytery proceeded in Siparia during this period. In the 1850s, the parish priest Fr. Kunes began construction of a new presbytery, which was completed by his successor, Fr. O'Hanlon. Moreover, during his tenure, Fr. O'Hanlon began erecting a new chapel. According to Fr. Doyle, the parish priest at the time of my fieldwork, then-Archbishop Louis Gonin donated \$312 toward the cost, and the rest was raised through the "contributions of devotees." There is no documentation of who these "devotees" were, but it is possible to infer that they included a significant number of "pagans," who started regular pilgrimages around the same period. For the parish of Siparia, seemingly buried in oblivion by the central authorities of the Catholic Church, abundant donations from Hindu pilgrims must have been nearly irresistible.

Although colonial, and subsequently postcolonial, society conceived of cultural purity as essential for status generation and regeneration, the Catholics in Siparia had to balance this with the necessities of "mixing," driven by the demographic and economic context. However, the Catholics in Siparia were not alone in being required to attain the apparently exclusive qualities of "mixing" and "purity" over the devotion to the statue of *La Divina Pastora*. The putative cultural "purity" was and remains essential for status generation of the Hindu celebrants of the statue. Their discovery of the statue's alleged healing power impelled Hindu devotees to also somehow worship the statue without becoming Catholics. They, too, desired a form of "mixing" that transgressed the putative colonial cultural bounds yet maintained the "purity" of their "true" Hindu religious practice.

The Catholics' historical reification of *Soparee Ke Mai* as distinct from *La Divina Pastora* intentionally set differing ritual practices and consciences against each other. However, the process of separation has always involved a process of integration, wherein cultural elements are *simultaneously* viewed as fundamentally

distinct and immiscible, and yet organically joined to each other. The play element of the statue's identification is a constant human production; accordingly, the Catholics' intention and decision has conditioned the orientation of ritual change. However, the development of separate celebrations of the statue has not remained under Catholics' rational and conscious ambition to govern. Ritualistically repeated, the Catholics' transfiguration of the statue's self with the original intention to satisfy contradictory "desires" eventually became related dialectically, but unconsciously, with the ritual practices of Hindu devotees, forming a signifying system operated by a "flow of desire" (Young, 1995: 166–167). The Catholics came to perceive themselves as entirely dependent on the versatile nature of the statue, enabling it to contend with opposing and competing forces through the contextual identification, which they have produced themselves. The dresses, which allow for the manifestation of distinct selves of the statue, have been tailored and put on by church members. However, as Ms. R. reiterated with emotion, "Mother [has given] her all the 'talents,' 'health' and 'strength'" with which she has thus far been capable of "serv[ing] the Mother." While changing statue's dress on Saturday after the Coolie Fête, Ms. R. told me in a triumphant tone, "Last year, a young Indian couple unable to have a baby came see her asking she blessing. They come back this year with a lot of offerings in return and told me that they were blessed for a child. She is really great." Such an "other's" story about "our" Mother continues to reinforce the Catholics' belief in the assumed power of their own Mother. The statue holds awe-inspiring power because it has assumed a certain independence, and become absent from, the consciousness of Catholics whose activities have drawn a distinction between the statue's identities and switched from the one self to the other self (Berger 1969: 96). When the Catholic Church could not exert power to prevent Hindustanis' ingression, the Church adopted measures to keep its own symbolic domain and religious practices sanctified and separate from the "spurious" cultural influence. Those artifices for the ritualistic conversion, when they became absent from their consciousness, came to constitute a "hyphen" linking distinct religious systems.

There was no separate Catholic feast of *La Divina Pastora*, known as "Siparia Fête" until the initiation of the separate Hindu pilgrimage on Holy Thursday and Good Friday. As usual, the Catholic Church in Siparia, became packed with Catholic pilgrims from all over the island, at times from abroad, who offer passionate prayer to *La Divina Pastora*. On my visit, although hundreds of extra chairs had been placed in precincts to accommodate the overflow, countless devotees still had to wait their turn to get at the statue and bend their ears to eulogies, outside the premises of the church. Following prayers, the parish priest and a group of church members who carried the statue on their shoulder, paraded through the town of Siparia, followed by a seemingly endless line of Catholic pilgrims. Upon their return, each pilgrim received a bottle of olive oil from the church. The Catholic

pilgrims knew that the oil in their hands came from Hindu's donation to *Soparee Ke Mai*. During their pilgrimage two weeks earlier, Hindu devotees brought a bottle of olive oil and poured a half a bottle into an oil-drum by the pedestal of the statue in Parish Hall. The Catholics used to take directly from this oil-drum on their feast day. A member of the church believed that the practice was discontinued and instead bottles of oil are handed out in order "to avoid the trouble" caused by Catholic pilgrims who rushed and scrambled for this alms. Contemporary Catholics "jostl[e] to obtain the oil in front of the Virgin" just like Hindu "pagans" in Fr. Masse's 19th-century description of "Coolie Fête." Catholics vie for and treasure the oil, despite the taken-for-granted fact that it reached their hands via the statue from religious and cultural "others." Hindu devotees donate olive oil applicable to Catholic ritual practice, instead of the coconut oil that they usually use in Hindu worship. Hindu pilgrims assume that the half bottle of olive oil they bring home from the Coolie Fête possesses power for "curing the sick" because they know that the half bottle donated to the statue from the same bottle will find its way into the hands of "others" (see also Osugi, 1999).

Being separated out *within* an integrated whole, Coolie Fête and Siparia Fête came to form a "micro-community with a nascent religion that is, in a real sense, its own" (Mintz and Price, 1976, cited in Glaziers, 1985), where the "purity" and legitimacy of the reified ritual practices and respective worldviews qualify only against each other. At this point, the "other" assumed a new implication: the "other"—Hindustanis for Catholics and Catholics for Hindus—has come to serve as the essential source of legitimation and authenticity for each group's own ritual performance in celebration of their own Mother. Only by being performed side-by-side, can the devotions for *Soparee Ke Mai* and *La Divina Pastora* allow the celebrants *both* to "mix" with others across established, socially accepted cultural bounds *and* to reconfirm the "purity" of their own ritual practices and respective consciences. Contrary to a recent academic abstraction of culture as hybrid, the feast of *Soparee Ke Mai* is not a "perpetual changing process of 'meaning-making'" (Baumann, 1997: 211) or a "permanently emergent culture" (Korom, 2002: 13). Those concerned have historically shared certain meanings that render the apparently inconsistent yet essential status-generative qualities of "mixing" and "purity" attainable without contradicting each other. In their perception, "mixing" represents less hybridization than hyphenation, which links reificatory cultures, and thus never puts the bearers in an either/or situation.

Notes

1. The Parish Hall is a multipurpose facility of roughly 900 square feet that is, according to a church member, "used for [the] community." It is situated between the main chapel and the adjoining boy's school as though it divides/connects them. The inside of the hall is painted plain white, and there is usually no religious object.

2. *Kurta*, or *kurti* for women, is a traditional item of clothing worn in northern India. It is a loose shirt-like dress for both sexes falling somewhere below the knees. Women might put on as everyday wear, but men wear it on formal occasions.
3. *Tika*, or *tilaka* (also spelled as *tilak*), is a mark on the forehead worn most often by (married) women and priests practicing Brahmanism on ceremonial and festive occasions. It is made of sandalwood paste, ashes, clay, or similar substances (Vertovec, 1992: 173).
4. *Abbé* is the title commonly used by the French for a priest who "engaged in parochial work" (Leahy, 1980: xiv).
5. Fr. Massé had already referred to Hindu worshippers of the statue in 1879: When he "went to pay [his] visit to La Divina Pastora... [Fr. Massé] saw a large number of idolatrous coolies. In their ignorance they adore the Blessed Virgin. A group of three coolies composed of three women of which two were old women and one young, and a man, advanced right into the sanctuary. The two old women fell on their knees and bowing deeply placed their foreheads on the ground during the time one takes to say several Our Fathers and Hail Marys. When they arose, one of them said a few words to the young one who prostrated herself in her turn in the same way and or six minutes. They then got up and fixed their eyes on the Virgin, addressed to her a prayer which really came from the heart... The Siparia pilgrimage resembles a lot certain ones of our country" (Massé, 1988 vol. II: 245–246).
6. *Ajoupa* is Amerindian-style thatched housing, which prevailed in Siparia at the end of the 19th century (Anthony, 2001: 301).
7. Every year, on the occasion of the Hindu pilgrimage, countless beggars fill up the playground of the Boys Catholic School that adjoins to the Catholic Church. They wait for a "share" of the offerings from the pilgrims. According to a parishioner, Siparia Fête does not attract many beggars because "they know that the Hindus give away much more than we [Catholics]." The offerings include foodstuffs, cooked foods, soft drinks, sweets, and, at times, money. The same parishioner added: "They [the beggars] are not necessarily poor. They often play poor."
8. There are various spellings. During my fieldwork, I saw at least the following three different spellings: *Suparee Ke Mai*, *Siparee Ke Mai*, and *Siparia Mai*.
9. For the role of religion in Indo-Trinidadian's transnational identity from the perspective of those who follow Islam, please see Aisha Khan's "Juthaa in Trinidad: Food, Pollution, and Hierarchy in a Caribbean Diaspora Community," in *American Ethnologist* 21(2): 245–269, in addition to Khan (2004) cited here.
10. Mahabir (2007), for example, explores the Hindu pilgrimage to Siparia and focuses on the potential identification of *Soparee Ke Mai* with Mother *Kali*. In Tsuji (2006), the leader of *Kali Mata Devi Mandir*, a temple in honor of Mother *Kali* in Trinidad, confirmed in the interview that "[*Soparee Ke Mai* and *Kali Mai* are] the same Mother. They're the same she."
11. Both the Hindu devotees to the statue and the parishioners of the Catholic Church in Siparia told me various stories that stress the punishment of immorality. For example, a female member of the Church and a male Hindu worshipper shared in separate interviews the same story of an "unfaithful" and "rude" Hindustani who lost his sight when he broke into the chapel with the intention of peeping the inside of the dress of the statue. C.L.R. James, a Trinidadian writer, developed a novelette, "*La Divina Pastora*," from the current folk belief that one's unethical deeds draw trouble on his/herself.

12. When the Catholic authorities kept Hindus on the wrong side of the chapel's door, the Hindu pilgrims threatened to burn the chapel down. The Catholic priest subsequently opened the door and let them in (Boodoo, 1993: 387).

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